



VAST COLONIES

Several of the penguin species that live around Antarctica nest on these islands, forming enormous breeding colonies. At least a million pairs of chinstrap penguins breed on Zavodovski, an active volcano in the South Sandwich Islands. They take advantage of the volcanic heat that melts the snow on the volcano's slopes, providing snow-free ground for nesting. This area has the largest concentration of penguins on Earth.

◀ KINGS AND QUEENS

The king penguin colony at Salisbury Plain on the shores of South Georgia attracts more than 100,000 breeding pairs; each pair raises a single chick.

REMOTE NESTS

These black-browed albatrosses mate for life and return to the same island to breed every year. They nest on the ground near the sea in large, noisy colonies. The birds can nest like this because the islands have no natural ground predators, such as foxes, to steal their eggs and young. Each pair has a single chick, which has to be fed by its parents for more than four months before it is able to fly and hunt for itself.



WOW!

Bird Island in South Georgia is home to more than 56,000 breeding albatrosses, and 100,000 penguins.

WHALING STATIONS

In the past, the islands were used as bases for hunting seals and whales. After the seals were almost wiped out, the hunters turned their attention to whales, with the same result. Commercial whaling was banned in 1986 to save the whales from extinction, and so the whaling stations on the islands were abandoned.

▼ RUSTING RELIC

A beached whale-hunting ship, complete with harpoon gun, lies near the former whaling station at Grytviken, South Georgia.

